

The Dhāraṇī by Which One Holds the Noble Great Pratisarā

Toh 588 · Derge Kangyur

This short text, catalogued as Toh 588 in the Kangyur, is a dhāraṇī connected with the noble Great Pratisarā (Mahāpratisarā), a female deity known as the queen of spells. The Tibetan title line preserved in the source is only partly legible, beginning with the word for "Jewel" or "Precious One," so the full Tibetan and Sanskrit titles cannot be given with confidence here; the translation's own closing line, however, identifies it as the dhāraṇī by which one comes to hold the noble Great Pratisarā. The text itself is extremely brief, consisting of an opening homage to the Three Jewels, a mantra beginning with a salutation to all the buddhas whose teaching is unobstructed, and a closing statement that holding this formula amounts to holding the goddess herself. As a dhāraṇī, it belongs to the class of protective incantations that Buddhist tradition treats as concentrated expressions of a deity's power and blessing, meant to be recited, memorized, or carried for protection. Within the canon it appears in the Kangyur, the collection of translated discourses attributed to the Buddha, among the tantra and dhāraṇī materials that center on protective spells.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Namaḥ samantabuddhānāṃ apratihataśāsanānāṃ. Oṃ maṇidhari vajriṇi mahāpratisare hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

By holding this, one comes to hold the noble Great Pratisarā (Mahāpratisarā), queen of spells.

Here ends the dhāraṇī by which one comes to hold the noble Great Pratisarā.

Translator's Notes

- The mantra is given in standard romanized Sanskrit, restored from the Tibetan transliteration. It means roughly: "Homage to all the buddhas, whose teaching is unobstructed. Oṃ, jewel-holder, vajra-bearer, Great Pratisarā, hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā." "Queen of spells" renders the Tibetan for Sanskrit vidyārājñī, meaning queen of vidyā-mantras. "Holding" carries the dhāraṇī sense of retaining, reciting, or wearing the spell.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.